Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9–1)

Thursday 11 June 2026
Morning (Time: 1 hour 30 minutes)

PAPER REFERENCE
1HI0/31

History

Paper 3: Modern depth study

Option 31: Weimar and Nazi Germany, 1918–39

Sources/Interpretations Booklet

Do not return this Booklet with the question paper.

Sources/Interpretations for use with Section B.
This booklet contains Source B, Source C, Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 for use with Question 3 on the question paper.

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Sources/Interpretations for use with Section B.

Sources for use with Questions 3(a) and 3(c).

Source B

From a secret Gestapo report on religious attitudes in Upper Bavaria, July 1937.

"We must report that the influence of the Catholic Church on the rural population remains unbroken. The Nazi spirit cannot penetrate these districts because the local population is entirely under the influence of the priests. These people prefer to believe what the priests say from the pulpit rather than the words of our best party speakers. When our officials attempted to remove crucifixes from the local schoolrooms, women gathered in protest, and we had to restore them to prevent civil unrest. The Concordat prevents us from making direct arrests of these priests during church services, which they exploit to spread subtle criticisms of the government's youth policies."

Source C

From a sermon preached by Pastor Martin Niemöller in Berlin, June 1937.

"We have no more desire than our fathers to stand in judgment over our rulers, but we must obey God rather than men. Our brother pastors are being arrested because they spoke the truth. The government's Reich Church seeks to replace the Cross of Christ with the Swastika, and to force our children into youth organisations that teach them to worship a man. We are told that if we remain silent, the Church will have peace. But I say to you, a silent Church is a dead Church. We must speak out, even if it leads us to the concentration camps."

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Interpretations for use with Section B.

Interpretations for use with Questions 3(b), 3(c) and 3(d).

Interpretation 1

From The Third Reich by Dr. Elizabeth Wilmott, published in 1997.

"The Christian Churches in Germany were largely successful in resisting the Nazi regime's attempts to achieve total control over religious life. Despite intense pressure, both the Catholic and Protestant Churches prevented the total Nazification of their institutions. The Concordat of 1933 protected the Catholic Church's independence, and when Hitler broke this agreement, the Pope's encyclical Mit Brennender Sorge was successfully read in churches across the nation, showing the limits of Nazi power. In the Protestant Church, the Confessing Church led a brave struggle that prevented Ludwig Müller's Reich Church from dominating German Protestants, proving that religious faith remained a powerful barrier to totalitarian control."

Interpretation 2

From Coercion and Consent by Professor Richard Bessel, published in 2004.

"Christian opposition to the Nazi regime was extremely limited, defensive, and ultimately failed to challenge the wider atrocities of the state. The vast majority of church leaders conformed to the regime because they shared Hitler's hatred of communism and feared the destruction of their institutions. When pastors like Niemöller spoke out, their protests were strictly limited to defending church independence and religious education; they did not protest against the police state, the banning of political parties, or the persecution of the Jews. The state successfully neutralized the churches through selective terror, arresting outspoken individuals while leaving the broader, compliant institutions intact."

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